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Life on Earth is shaped by the rocks that lie beneath our feet. Made of different combinations of minerals, they have a far-reaching influence on the landscape, on vegetation, and on the soil. Preserved within these rocks, fossils form a highly detailed record of life in the distant past, showing the path that evolution has followed over hundreds of millions of years.



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MINERALS

The building blocks of rocks, minerals typically have a crystalline structure. Several thousand exist in Earth's crust, but fewer than 50 minerals are common and widespread.



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ROCKS

Classified according to how they formed, rocks are constantly broken down and reformed. The oldest rocks date back 3.8 billion years, when Earth's crust first solidified.



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FOSSILS

Most fossils preserve hard remains, such as teeth and bones. They can also include traces such as footprints, and carbon impressions in rock, which reveal the past existence of living things.